



Will **HYPERLOOP** Actually Transform Public Transport in India?

India has emerged as an unlikely contender for introducing a pioneering mode of public transport globally, but how transformative can it actually be?

Souvik Das | souvik@digit.in

The hype surrounding Hyperloop hasn't died down, ever since Tesla and SpaceX CEO, Elon Musk floated the concept. On February 18, Virgin founder Richard Branson stated that his Hyperloop One team is working alongside the Maharashtra government to establish a Hyperloop route in India, which may well be the first one in the world. Is that feasible? If so, how will it work out? We try to break it down for you.

What is Hyperloop?

As per the initial 'Hyperloop Alpha' concept paper floated by Musk, Hyperloop is a futuristic mode of

transport that is built on elevated or underground vacuum tubes. Inside these tubes, specialised pod-like structures will carry passengers along at speeds that can theoretically reach up to 1,000km/h. The Hyperloop's initial presentation addresses more than just the speed it will boast.

For one, Hyperloop will work in the same way as urban, short-distance metro railway lines, on a larger scale. Vacuum tubes will be used for the 'track', which ensures less load on roadways and addresses the growing concern of traffic in urban spaces. These tubes and pods will generate their own electricity for plying via solar panels along the tubes. This reduces the carbon footprint and

travel emissions while addressing the concern of extra energy consumed.

Furthermore, Hyperloop's potential speed can ensure that a large number of individuals can travel back and forth cities that are as far as 400 kilometres apart, on a regular basis.

Hyperloop is one of the alternate travelling modes that are being touted for the future, along with flying taxis. However, the idea of slick pods travelling along straight vacuum tubes that connect multiple cities sound like a far superior idea.

Why India?

In India, the cost factor may play a key factor. The Mumbai-Pune corridor that has been earmarked as a potential inaugural Hyperloop route, which relies majorly on road and rail.